NOTES

BRIEFING FOR CITY COUNCIL · **GROUP 3**

260 menu items per container

**Serving size** **one dot**

# Would you like sugar with that?

The council is weighing a fast-food ban. A ban treats all 260 menu items the same. We read the nutrition facts of every one to see where the problem actually sits. **Spoiler: 150 of them are not the problem.**

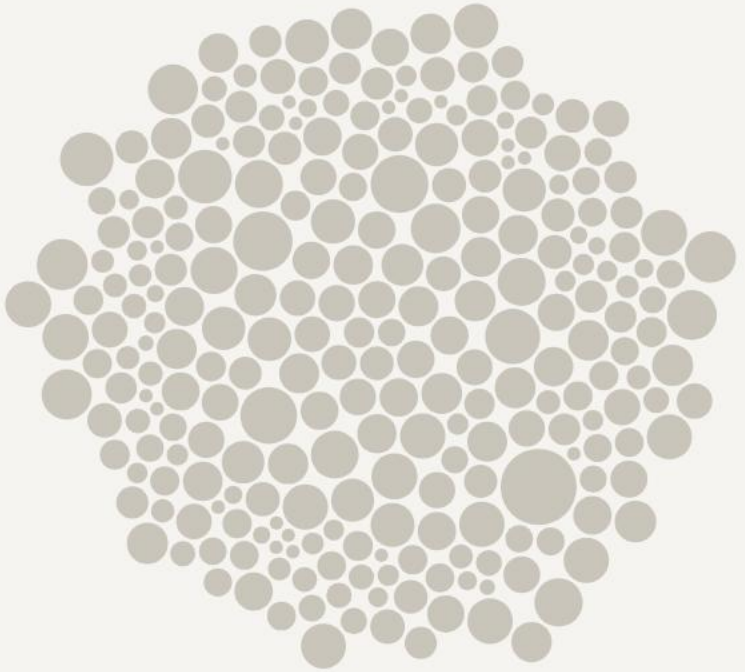
**Menu items analysed** **260**

A blanket ban removes 260 items. The data flags 110.

HOW TO READ

Each dot is one menu item. Bigger dot, more calories.

IE IMBA Data Fluency · Final group assignment. Use the arrow keys or a clicker to move through the story.



260 items. Where does the problem sit?

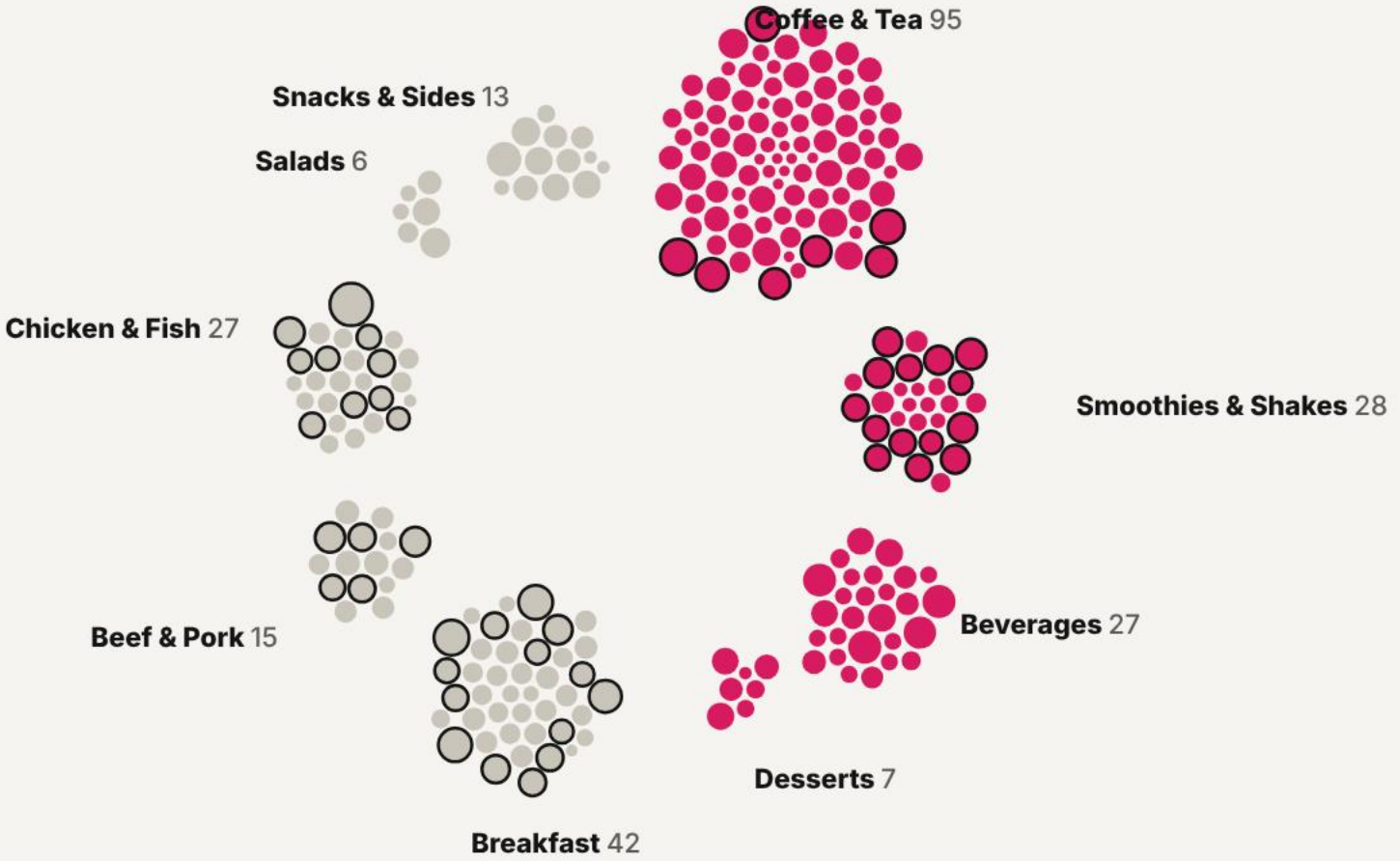
Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

NOTES

# Six in ten menu items are drinks or desserts

157 of the 260 items are coffees, sodas, shakes or desserts. 21 of them carry more calories than a Big Mac.

**Drinks & desserts** **60%**




KEY

- Drinks & desserts
- Food
- More calories than a Big Mac (530)

all 260 dots are in our dashboard →

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

NOTES

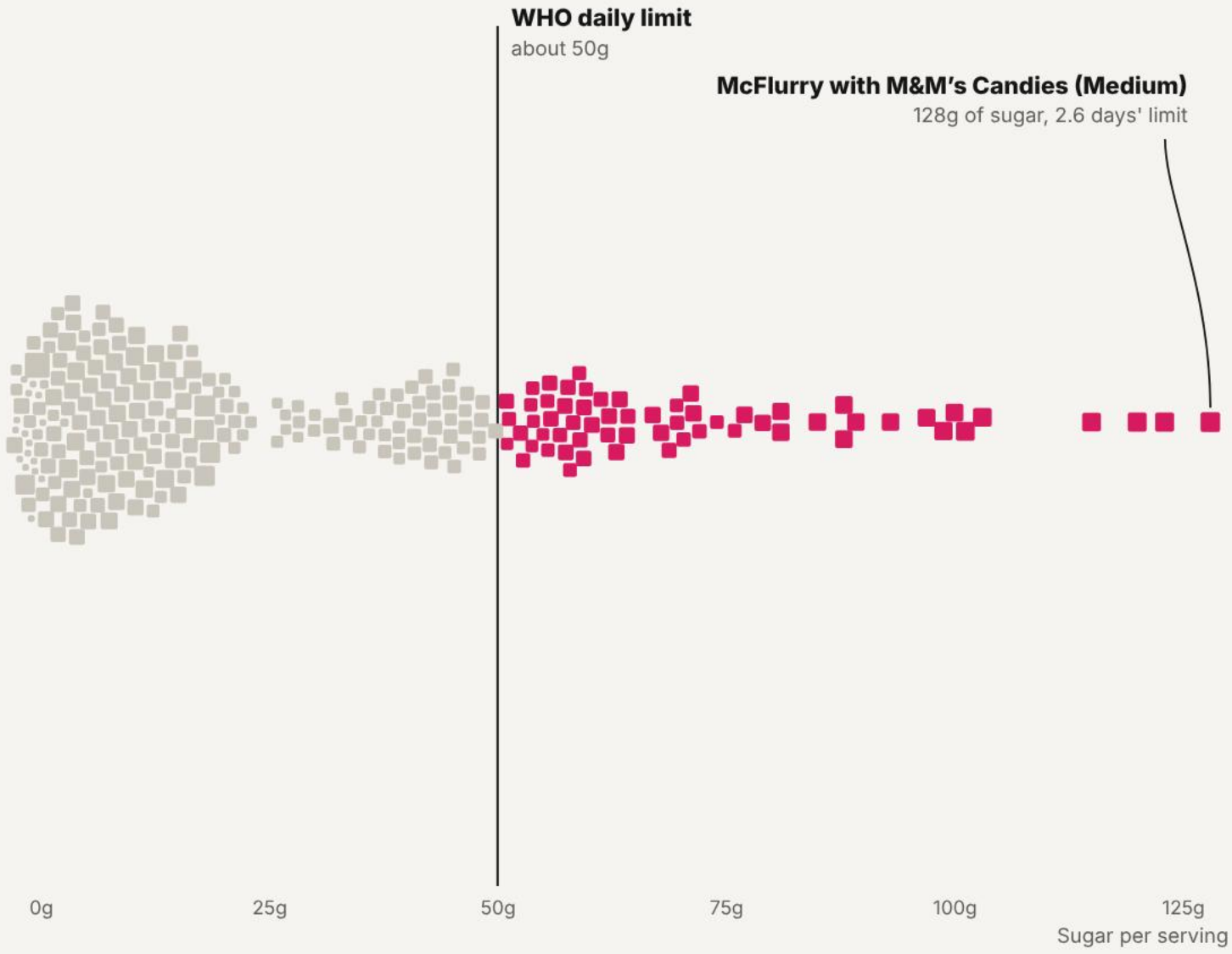
# Every item over the daily sugar limit comes in a cup

62 items pass the WHO limit of about 50g in a single serving: shakes, McFlurries, sodas and sweet coffees. The sweetest food item has 32g.

**Items over 50g of sugar** **62**

KEY

- Over 50g of sugar
- Under 50g
- Bigger square, more calories




Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

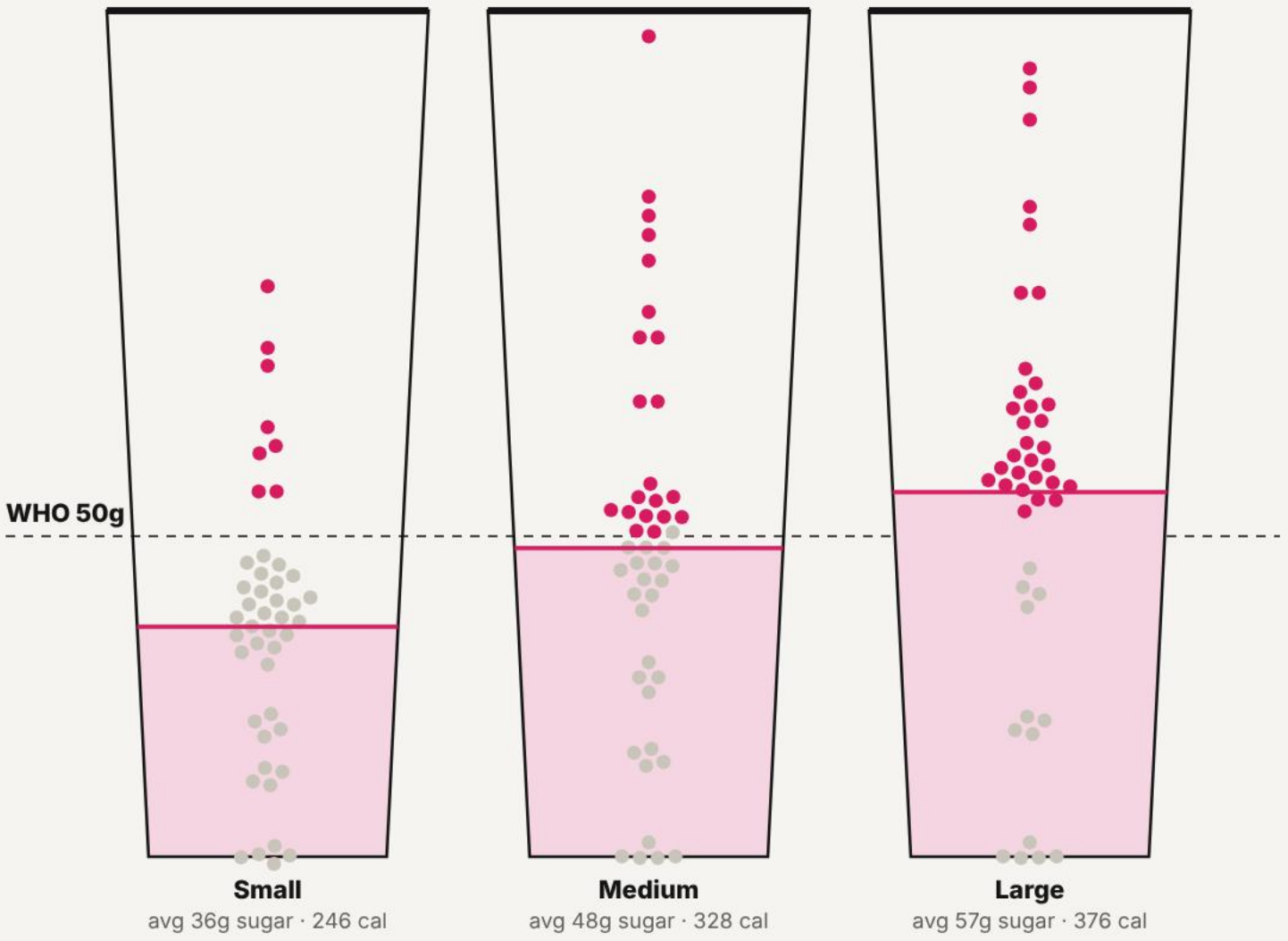
# Each size up adds about 10g of sugar

Across 136 drinks sold in three sizes, the average Small has 36g of sugar, the Medium 48g and the Large 57g. The average Large is over the daily limit on its own.

**Large vs Small** **+21g**

KEY

- Over 50g of sugar
- Under 50g
- Fill line: average sugar per size. **Read the line, not the pink area.**




Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

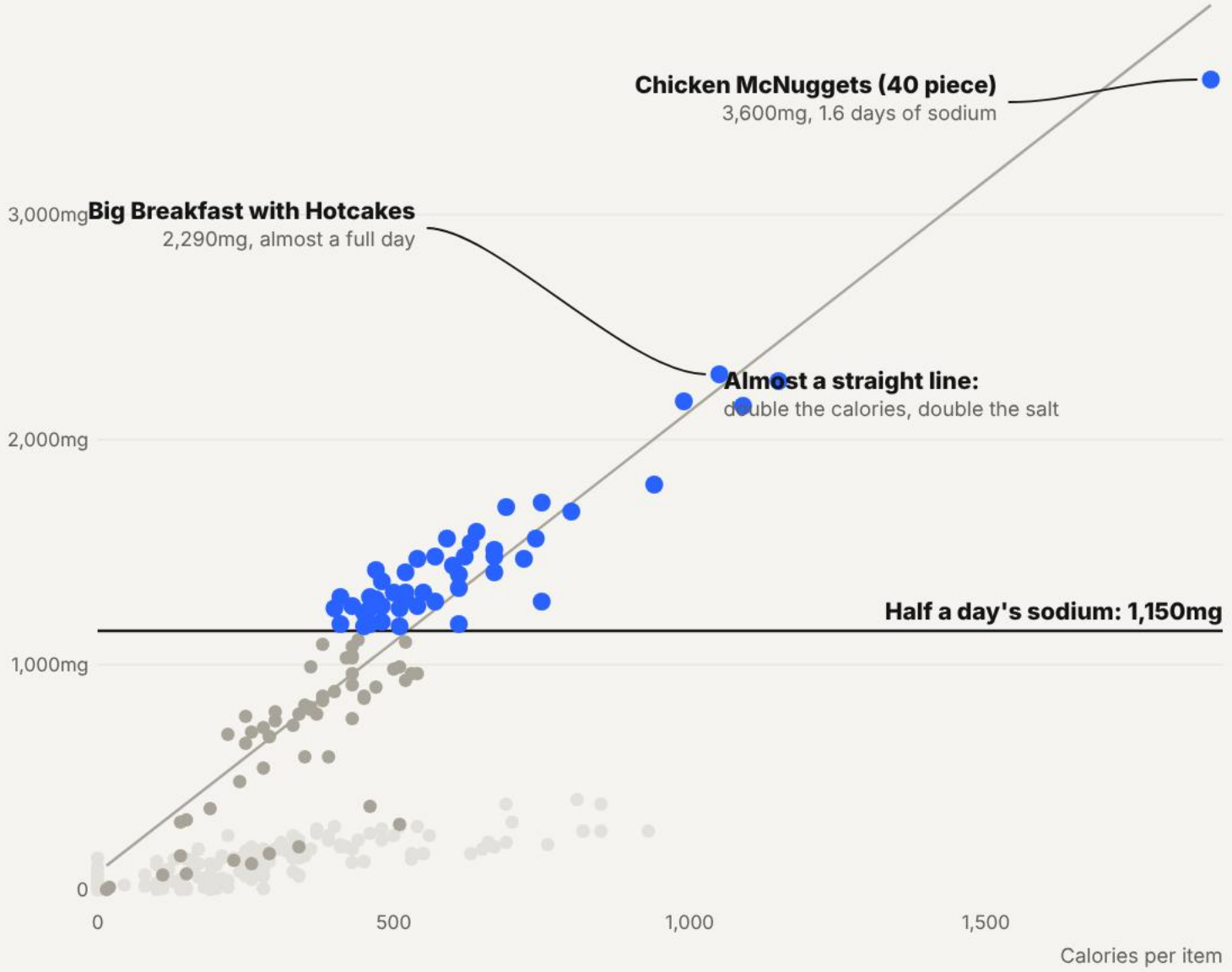
# On the plate, the problem is salt

Food items barely carry sugar, but 48 of them hold half a day's sodium or more. The more calories on the plate, the saltier it gets.

**Items with 1,150mg+ sodium** **48**

KEY

- Food with 1,150mg+ sodium
- Other food
- Drinks & desserts




Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

SERVING 5 OF 6 · **SWAPS**

# Same order, smaller or grilled

All 13 chicken dishes sold both ways lose 80 to 160 calories when grilled. A Small instead of a Large saves a median 130 calories and 21g of sugar.

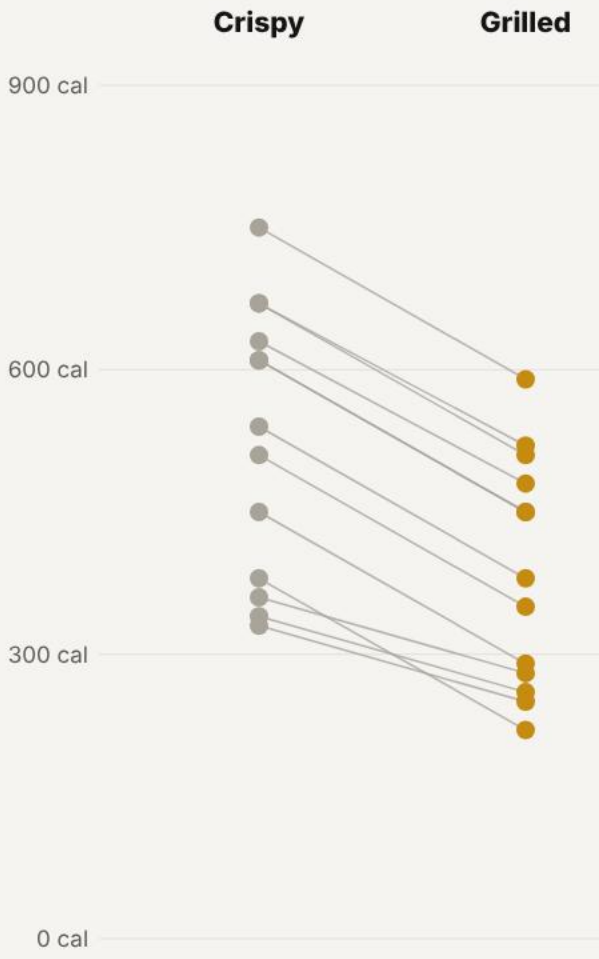
**Calories saved per grilled dish**

**80–160**

KEY

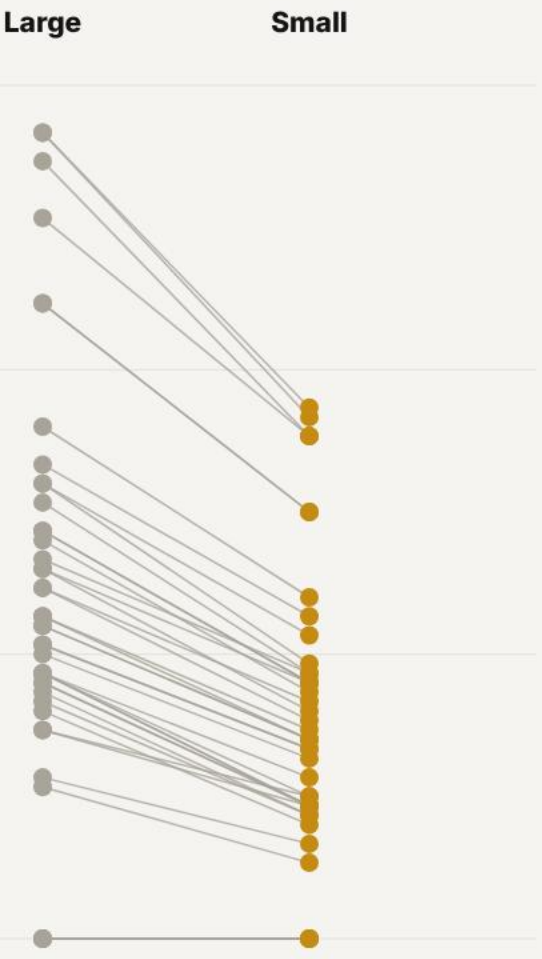
- What people order now
- The smarter version

13 chicken dishes sold both ways




**Every dish drops: 80 to 160 cal**

43 drinks sold in Small and Large




**Median: 130 cal and 21g sugar**

Flat lines: diet sodas, coffee, iced tea

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

SERVING 6 OF 6 · POLICY

# Regulate the cup, not the counter

A ban removes all 260 items. Two warning labels would flag the 110 items that drive the problem and leave the other 150 alone.

**Items flagged** **110**

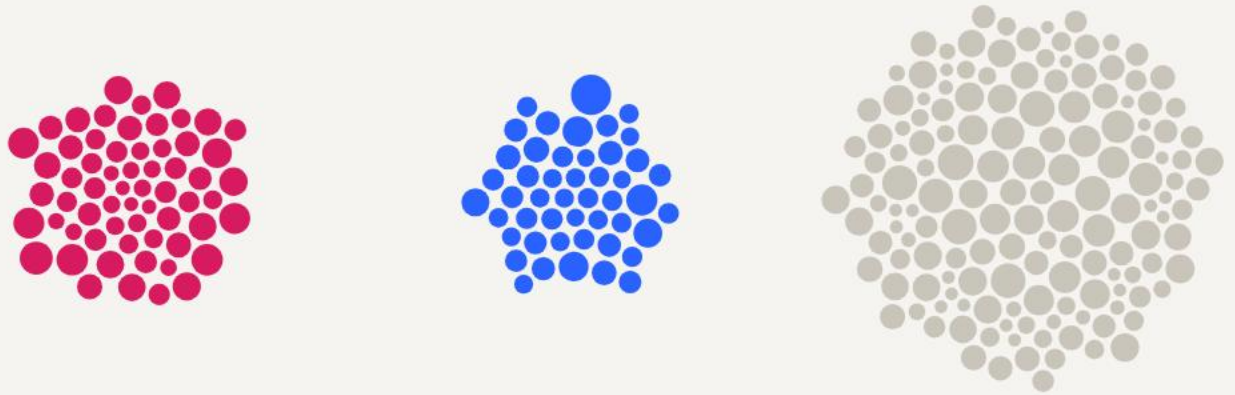
KEY

- Sugar over 50g
- Sodium 1,150mg or more
- No flag

**Sugar over 50g**
62 items, all in a cup

**Sodium 1,150mg+**
48 items, all food

**No flag**
150 items



| MEASURE | REACHES | WHAT THE DATA SAYS |
|---|---|---|
| **Small as the default drink size** | 136 drinks | Median 130 fewer calories and 21g less sugar per drink |
| **Sugar warning at 50g+** | 62 items | Every one of them comes in a cup |
| **Sodium warning at 1,150mg+** | 48 items | New York City's 2,300mg icon would flag only 1 item here |
| **Grilled listed first on menu boards** | 13 dishes | 80 to 160 fewer calories per dish |

Precedents: New York City requires chain restaurants to show a salt-shaker icon next to items with 2,300mg of sodium or more. California makes water or plain milk the default drink in kids' meals (SB 1192).

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

AFTER THE MEAL · **RECOMMENDATION**

# Pilot targeted rules before any ban

> Decision we ask for today: approve a six-month Small-by-default pilot with two or three chains.

Start where the data points: the drink cup and the salt on the plate. Measure what people actually order, then decide.

KEY

- Sugar flag
- Sodium flag
- No flag

## NEXT STEPS

**Pilot Small-by-default** with two or three chains for six months.

**Ask chains for sales data.** A menu shows what is offered, not what is eaten.

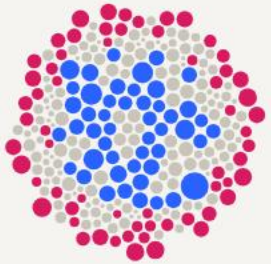
**Repeat with local menus.** Portions and recipes differ by country.

## WHAT THIS DATA CAN'T TELL US

**One chain, one menu.** 260 McDonald's items, US nutrition facts.

**No sales volumes.** A rarely ordered shake counts as much as fries.

**Thresholds are ours.** 50g sugar and 1,150mg sodium follow WHO and US daily values.



## SOURCES AND TOOLS

**Data:** Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu, Kaggle (US menu, 260 items)

**Sugar limit:** WHO Guideline on sugars intake for adults and children (2015)

**Sodium warning:** NYC Department of Health, Sodium Warning Rule

**Kids' meal drinks:** California Department of Public Health, SB 1192 fact sheet

**Tools:** Looker Studio dashboard and D3.js. Built with AI assistance (Claude); analysis and recommendations by Group 3.

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

NOTES

AFTER THE MEAL · ONE DECISION

# Approve a six-month Small-by-default pilot.

Start small, measure what people actually order, then decide. Madrid keeps its menu and loses the sugar.

> Thank you for listening. Questions welcome.

WHAT THE DATA SAYS

- 62 items over 50g of sugar. Every one comes in a cup.
- 48 dishes with half a day of sodium. Every one is food.
- 150 items touched by neither flag. A ban would remove them too.

SUGAR · REGULATE THE CUP

## 62

items over the daily limit in one serving. All of them drinks or desserts. A sugar warning at 50g reaches every one.

SALT · WARN, DON'T BAN

## 48

dishes with half a day of sodium. All of them food. A sodium icon at 1,150mg, as New York does at 2,300mg.